

Must-have App: Beatwave

Beatwave is a synthesizer that lets you create music loops easily. Best part: no matter what you do, it still sounds like music in the end (Free)

Must-have App: Google Earth

Really? You need a reason beyond "Google Earth iPad exists" to get Google Earth on the iPad? (Free)

Musing on the iPad

What remains when you've run out of lust? (And other magical stories)



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Why, I must ask myself, am I writing about the iPad now, when it's been out for yonks (in tech terms, at least), and everyone from professional reviewer to unprofessional pillock has taken great liberties with the thesaurus in describing its wondrousness? I'll tell you why, children. It's because only after time passes and the halo and hype have faded away – leaving room for the Next Big Thing™ – do we see the true nature of the shiny things we fell for. Will we chalk it down to a moment of weakness and deny we ever bought this horrible thing, or will we settle into what promises to be a long, healthy and loving relationship, at least until the next one arrives?

I suppose I must mention that when

the iPad was announced, I was astonished at my own optimism. Could this be the first thing launched in recent memory that doesn't suck? Would I have bought one if someone else hadn't already paid for the one I have? The answers to those questions, it turns out, are yes and no, respectively.

Let me first point out that the iPad is exactly what a portable computer should be. Does a few things, does them really, really well, ARM-based, and with a battery that requires a conscious effort to drain. It's also what a tablet user interface should be – fully aware that users will

be using their fingers, not a mouse, and designed to reflect that.

I read plenty of early criticism that the iPad isn't "magical and revolutionary" because it doesn't run a "bonafide" OS like Windows or Mac OS X. "I won't buy a tablet that doesn't run Windows", to paraphrase one particular forum (not ThinkDigit) commenter person. If you identify with this statement, read on.

First, take that bucket off your head – it makes you look silly and miss stuff. Like the fact that Windows-based tablets have been around for ages. Like in all those years, they've never found much of a following. Because they were rubbish. And expensive. But mostly rubbish – think boiling hot sewage served on a platter of mouldy bread.

"But surely Mac OS X is worthy of the tablet treatment," you might reply, "I've tried Ink with a graphics tablet, and it's really good." To which I would point out,

"Have you seen the close button on windows on the Mac? They're really hard to hit with a mouse cursor, much less with your flabby fingers. And don't interrupt me." No – putting an OS designed for keyboards and mice on a device for fingers is a recipe for, well, hot sewage pizza, and if you can say otherwise with a straight face, you are deluded. Or Steve Ballmer.

Right then; where was I?

The fit

Here's an interesting strategy to save yourself from misery – instead of emptying your bank account every time a pretty gadget hits the market, try to visualise where it fits into your life. For example, I see a Nokia N900 fitting into mine quite neatly – it runs Linux, so I can use vi to write my articles anywhere; it's got a TV out and will pair to a bluetooth keyboard, so I can actually do that writing with a proper keyboard and a proper display. It is, in fact, the mobile computer I'd much rather be writing about right now, if I could afford the damned thing.

Coming back to the iPad – I could picture that fitting into my life too. iBooks is a big, fat reason right there – I love books, e or otherwise. So is the fact that now that it's got Pages, it becomes a much lighter portable workstation than my current laptop. Of course, there's the whole user experience thing, but it's really the reading and writing that takes the iPad beyond just "big iPod Touch".

Unfortunately, the reading part gets kicked in the groin when you realise that the iPad weighs 650 grams, is top-heavy, and doesn't lend itself well to gripping. To address those in order – 650 grams is more than your average paperback, and perhaps more than a hard-bound